



WELL KNIT: Team India with the cup and (right) coach Houghton

Indian football. For a start, the staid National Football League (NFL) is set for a complete restructure. It will also get a hip new name—the I-League, on the lines of Japan's J-League and Singapore's S-League. The number of participating teams remains 10 this year as it has been for a while but two new teams will be added every year from 2008 onwards.

With big corporate houses buying out clubs and setting up teams, the domestic game is heading for a turnaround and not just in the old strongholds like Bengal and Kerala but in new cities as well. The Piramal Group is starting Pune FC and the Essel Group in Mumbai is putting together Mumbai FC. In Delhi, Osians, primarily an art auction house, has bought over one of the Capital's oldest teams, New Delhi Heroes and plans to pump in about Rs 2 crore to make it a national-level team. It has hired Cheema Okeri, one of Indian club football's most famous names, as coach. The group is also the title sponsors for the 119-year-old Durand Cup.

Added to these developments is some aggressive promotion on television. Zee Sports had bought Indian domestic football rights for 10 years for Rs 278 crore. There is every indication that the deal will be renewed for another 10 years soon. The TRPs have obviously been more than encouraging. According to Satish Menon, Zee Sports' Deputy CEO, Zee's early research showed that though popular at school

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PLAYING CATCH UP

■ Zee Sports signed a Rs 278-crore deal for domestic rights for 10 years. The deal is set to be renewed for 10 more years.

■ TRP ratings of the last World Cup and all Champions League matches often rival cricket Test matches.

■ India's coach Bob Houghton is on a two-year contract worth \$2,00,000 annually, roughly equal to the cricket coach's pay.

level, football did not throw up outstanding talent due to insufficient exposure at the national level and zero emotional connect to the game. Their solution was to concentrate on high-quality production with 12-14 cameras. Today the channel even tutors corporates on how to manage clubs.

Rival ESPN-Star has also noted that its TRPs for the 2006 World Cup football matches rivalled even cricket Test matches. "The fan-following for international soccer has been rising," says R.C. Venkatesh, managing director, ESPN Software Private Limited. In addition to airing international tournaments and hosting football-related programmes, ESPN's 'Learning Ground' initiative in more than 1,200 schools also promotes the game.

At the domestic club level, football has also undergone tremendous commercialisation. Goa football is the best example of excellence at the club level with four of the 10 NFL teams coming from the state. Colaco says that this has been possible due to "the willingness to spend large sums in getting the best players, good local competition, a good football environment and constructive involvement of the club bosses".

Similarly, Kerala has seen a turnaround of sorts with new teams like Viva Kerala making it to the NFL within two years of its birth. IFA, the parent body of football in Bengal, has sold its Kolkata League rights to Bangla news channel Star Ananda for Rs 12.41 crore. AIFF Vice-President Subrata Dutta brought in two corporate biggies, Exide Chairman S.B. Ganguly and Officer's Choice's Utpal Ganguly, as president and secretary of IFA. He also appointed a PR agency to look after IFA's affairs. The result: even a lesser known team like Chirag United has a sponsor. Mohammedan Sporting, one of Kolkata's most glorious clubs which went years without a sponsor, is now backed by Reliance.

Corporate patronage coupled with media hype has ensured that the players also smile their way to the bank. A top Indian defender has reportedly signed a Rs 1-crore contract with a Mumbai-based club. This was an unheard-of fee even a year ago. Clearly, all the game needed was money and a bit of passion. Now, hopefully more trophies will follow. ■